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Alton Ford, former player for Milby, UH, Rockets, dies at 36

By **Joseph Duarte**, UH/Big 12 Beat Writer

Updated April 3, 2018 10:23 p.m.

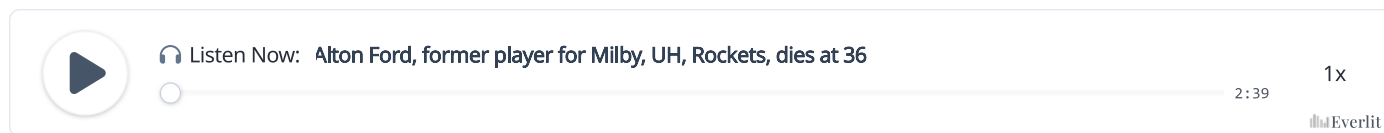


PHOTOS: Alton Ford in high school and college

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Alton Ford, a "gentle giant" who was a McDonald's All-American at Milby High School and played one season at the University of Houston before leaving for the NBA, passed away Monday night after a lengthy battle with cancer. He was 36.

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An intimidating 6-9, 260-pound forward, Ford was one of the top players to come out of the Houston Independent School District in recent decades, averaging nearly 24 points and 15 rebounds and earning McDonald's All-American honors as a senior at Milby. He played one season for the Cougars, averaging 10.8 points and 5.9 rebounds per game in 2000-01 before deciding to turn pro.

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"He was quite a character," said Jim Duffer, Ford's former coach at Milby. "The word gentle giant is just an absolute great characteristic that he had. He just was a sweet kid. When you got on the court he was a man and wasn't going to back down

to anybody. But he was such a gentle person off the court and had such a charismatic smile and booming laugh. What a great kid."

Ford was selected by the Phoenix Suns with the 50th overall pick in the 2001 NBA draft. Ford averaged 2.5 points and 1.7 rebounds in two seasons with the Suns. He appeared in nine games for the Rockets during the 2003-04 season before playing overseas for five seasons. He played the final years of his career in the NBA D-League until retiring in 2011.

"The Suns organization is saddened this morning by the passing of former Suns forward Alton Ford , who was a beloved teammate and friend to man during his two seasons in Phoenix," the organization posted on Twitter. "We share our deepest condolences with Alton's friends & family."



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Sports Illustrated

Ford was diagnosed with stage-4 lymphoma in late November, according to a video posted on Facebook. A celebration of Ford's life will be held at 11 a.m. Saturday at Daryl's Place (3330 Avenue A) in Santa Fe. Proceeds from the crawfish boil will go to Ford's family to assist with medical bills and funeral costs.

Ford is survived by his wife Victoria and three children. He is preceded in death by his mother, Carol Ford.

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"She did such a great job of raising that kid," Duffer said.

Funeral arrangements are pending.

April 3, 2018 | Updated April 3, 2018 10:23 p.m.

**Joseph Duarte**

UH/BIG 12 BEAT WRITER



Joseph Duarte covers University of Houston athletics and the Big 12 Conference for the Houston Chronicle. He can be reached at joseph.duarte@houstonchronicle.com.

A University of Texas at Austin graduate, Joseph joined the Houston Chronicle as part of an internship through the Sports Journalism Institute in 1995 and never left. He previously wrote about the Houston Astros from 1998-2002, Houston Texans from 2002-05 and the Texas Longhorns from 2005-09.

Joseph's work has been recognized nationally by the Associated Press Sports Editors and in 2022 he was named the Celeste Williams Star Sportswriter of the Year by the Texas Association of Managing Editors.

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